Project 4 Report

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For Prototype 1, I created a simple platform setup to help players get familiarized with the key moment-to-moment interactions (running, jumping, tagging bunnies) while being constrained by the visibility circle. The platform layout was designed to be a narrow space that has more uni-directional than branching pathways to guide first-time players. I also scattered items like books and plants to encourage players to explore the space and interact with these items. The goal of the prototype was to determine whether the visibility range worked effectively with the platform/items layout to communicate possible player actions.

My uncertainties were the opacity of the visibility circle and the placement of the platforms, books, and plants. I struggled with creating spaces that were not too convoluted, yet challenging enough to be enticing to the players. I knew where all the bunnies were hidden so seeing the game through the lens of a first-time exposure was difficult.

Thankfully, playtesting with others came in handy when dealing with these issues. Hugo pointed out that the character's head that was bouncing against the platforms disrupted its movement and suggested I switch my solid platforms to jump-through ones, which I did. He thought my bunnies were well hidden. My platform layout was navigatable but it was preferable to space them out more, so I tweaked this in subsequent levels. I also learned that the basic movement actions worked, the tagging mechanism functioned properly, and the goal was clear. My visibility filter was semi-transparent at first, but I later increased its opacity to better conceal surrounding information, or else it defeated the purpose of this constraint's existence. I also implemented a "+1" feedback that appears when the player tags a bunny. While playtesting, I realized that my teammates unintentionally tagged a bunny without knowing it, so this feedback became crucial. After refining all these elements in Prototype 1, I was convinced that the visibility constraint and placement of objects worked well together and the players knew what actions were available to them, so I was ready to add another challenge to Prototype 2: ghost bunnies.

For Prototype 2, my goal was to check if I had a gradual transition in difficulty between Level 1 to Level 2 which introduced ghost bunnies. I intended to have only two levels. However, the second level proved to be too difficult after playtesting with Enric because the behaviour of the ghost bunnies was not yet clear, and the layout was a prospect space void of items which made it challenging to navigate (*see Appendix, Figure 2*). Therefore, I had to include a transitional level between the first and second scenes. This new Level 2 was a short level that harboured both invisible and fully-visible bunnies. I reduced the time for when the bunnies are fully invisible so players can adapt to the notion of invisibility. I also removed invisibility when the bunnies are running. I simplified the space by building it within an elongated rectangle so that the players move from one end of the rectangle to the other without getting lost in a maze of platforms (*see Appendix, Figure 1*). In Level 3, I scattered more items since they served as landmarks to make the prospect space feel less daunting (*see Appendix, Figure 3*). I initially planned on introducing a time crunch in Level 3, but since I felt like the players were not familiar with the ghost bunnies challenge yet, I decided against adding the extra time constraint. Amanda enjoyed how the bunnies started running around after Level 1 and found the difficulty level and progression just right.

To further the development of my game idea, I would explore the bunny's invisibility property combined with space. For instance, I would alter the bunnies' opacity when they are running across the platforms and see how players adapt to that. Once players familiarize themselves with the ghost bunnies, I would intensify the time constraint with the use of music that speeds up to signify that time is running out. This sensory time-indicating tool will add more tension.

Appendix

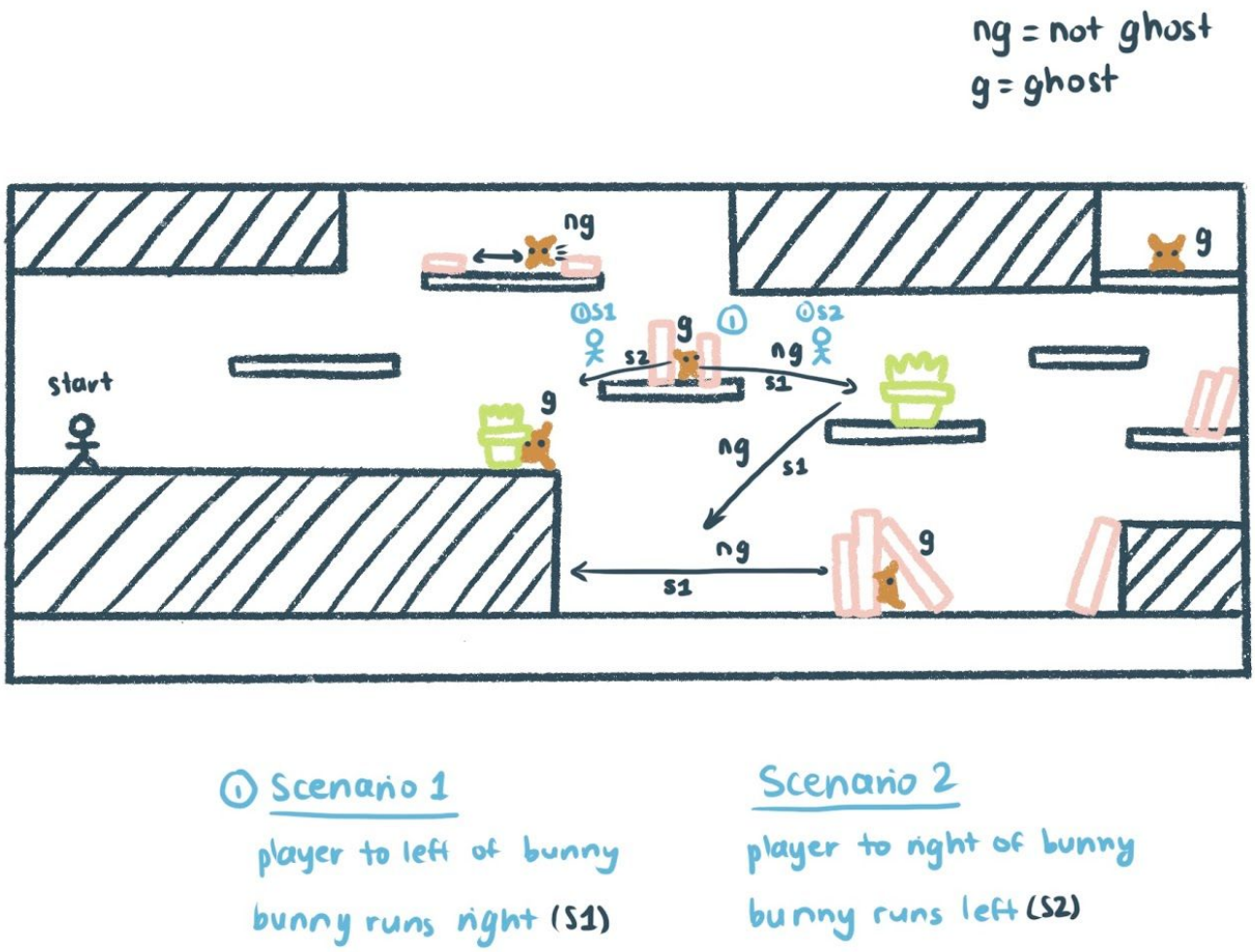

Figure 1: Original setup of Level 2

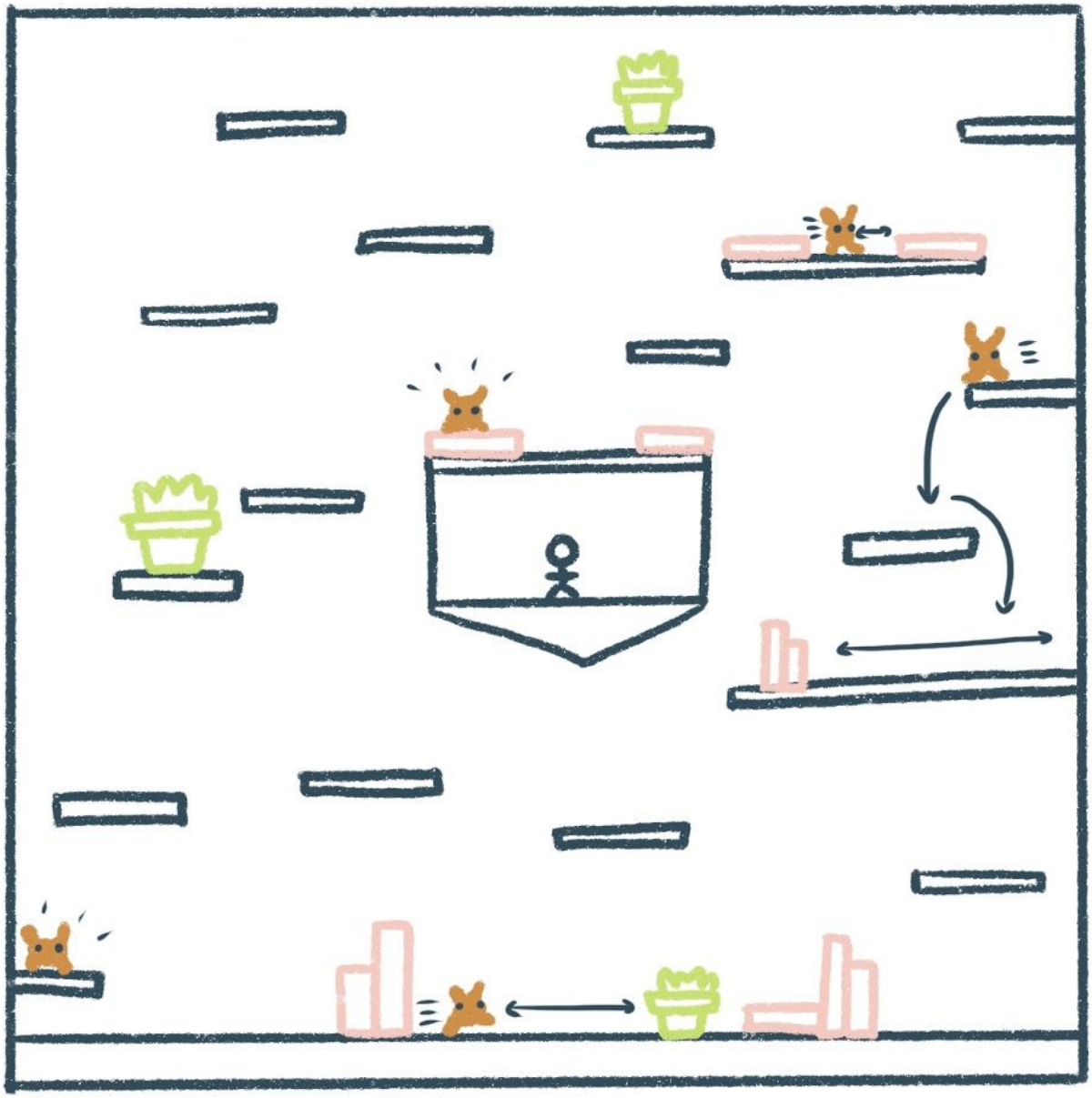

Figure 2: Original setup of Level 3

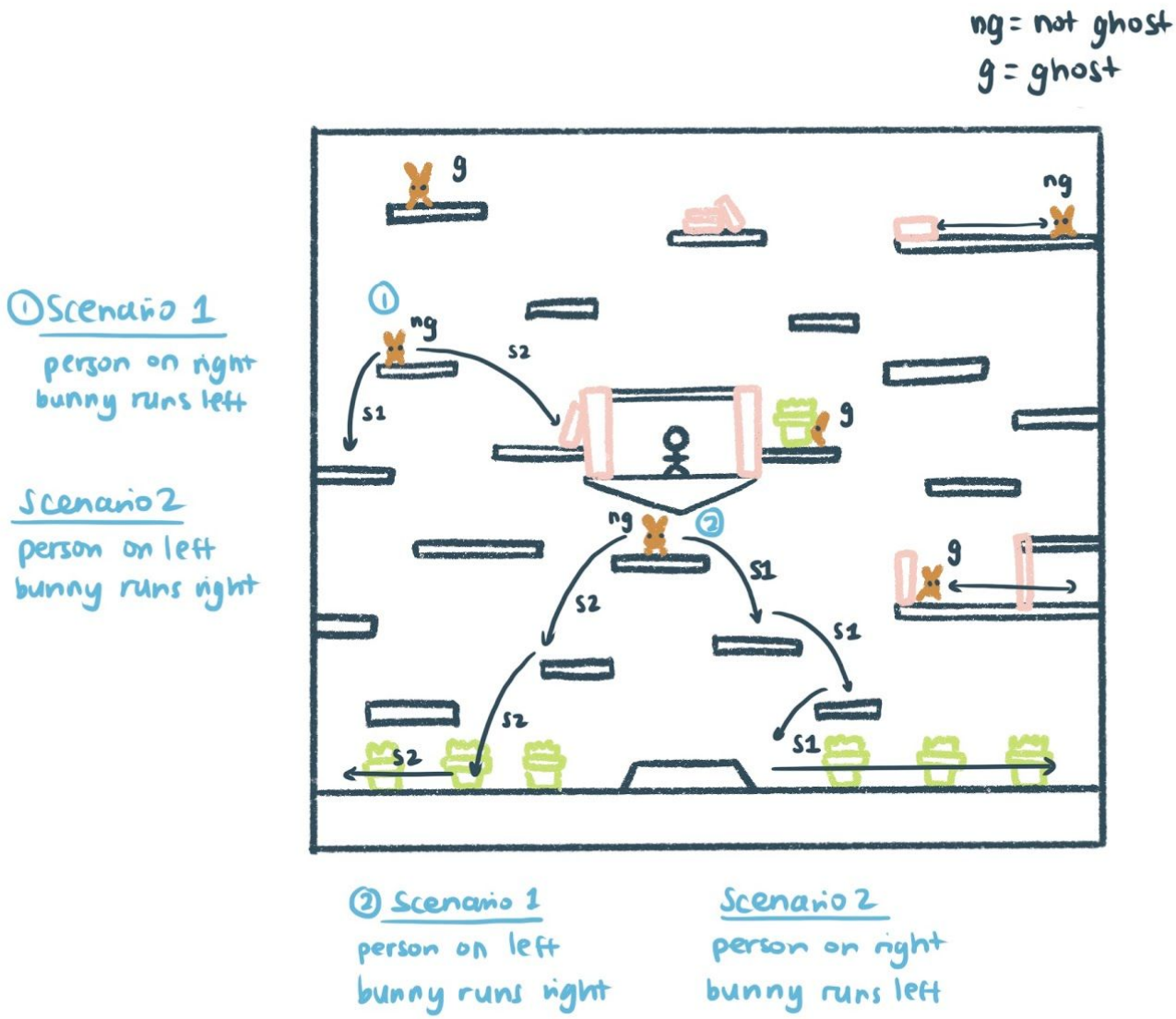

Figure 3: Revised setup of Level 3